YOGA ASANAS KNOWLEDGE BASE

Source-Grounded Reference for Therapeutic and Educational Use

1. STANDING ASANAS

TADASANA

Sanskrit Name: Tadasana
English Name: Mountain Pose
Meaning of Name: Tada means mountain in Sanskrit[1]

Category: Standing Asana
Difficulty Level: Beginner

Description:
Tadasana serves as the foundational standing posture in yoga practice. The posture emphasizes vertical alignment of the body with weight distributed evenly across both feet. Traditional yogic texts describe this asana as establishing the foundation for all other standing poses through proper postural awareness.[2][3]

Step-by-Step Practice:
The practitioner begins by standing with feet together or hip-width apart, ensuring even weight distribution across all four corners of each foot. The legs remain active with kneecaps gently lifted and thigh muscles engaged. The pelvis maintains neutral alignment while the spine elongates upward. Arms hang naturally alongside the body with palms facing the thighs. The chin remains parallel to the ground with the gaze directed forward. The posture is held for 30 seconds to 1 minute with steady, natural breathing.[3][2]

Benefits:
Tadasana improves postural awareness and body alignment. The pose strengthens the legs and develops core stability. Regular practice enhances balance and proprioception. Traditional yogic understanding suggests the pose promotes mental focus and groundedness, though limited scientific evidence supports specific therapeutic claims.[4][5][2][3]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary muscles engaged include the quadriceps, gluteal muscles, and core stabilizers. Secondary muscles

include the erector spinae, gastrocnemius, and intrinsic foot muscles. The proprioceptive system is actively involved in maintaining balance.[4][2]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with severe balance issues should practice near a wall or with support. Those with orthostatic hypotension should rise slowly from seated positions before practicing. Pregnant women after the first trimester should avoid prolonged motionless standing.[6][7][4]

Common Mistakes:
Common alignment errors include locking the knees, which reduces circulation and stability. Practitioners often shift weight predominantly to one leg rather than maintaining even distribution. Holding tension in the shoulders or jaw contradicts the principle of stable alertness.[2][3]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners may practice with feet hip-width apart for greater stability. Those with balance difficulties can practice with the back against a wall. Advanced practitioners may practice with eyes closed to challenge proprioception.[6][2]

Sources:

- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[3]
- NCCIH Yoga Safety Guidelines[6][4]

VRKSASANA

Sanskrit Name: Vrksasana
English Name: Tree Pose
Meaning of Name: Vrksa means tree in Sanskrit, representing balance and growth[8][1]

Category: Standing Asana, Balancing
Difficulty Level: Beginner to Intermediate

Description:
Vrksasana is described in the Gheranda Samhita as a posture representing balance and growth. The asana requires maintaining stability on one leg while the other foot is placed against the standing leg.

Traditional teaching emphasizes the development of concentration and steadiness through this pose.[1][8][2]

Step-by-Step Practice:

Begin in Tadasana with weight evenly distributed. Shift weight onto the left foot, grounding through all four corners. Bend the right knee and place the right foot against the left inner thigh or calf, avoiding direct pressure on the knee joint. The standing leg remains straight with the knee facing forward. Hands may be placed at the heart center or extended overhead. The gaze fixes on a stationary point at eye level to support balance. Hold for 30 seconds to 1 minute, then repeat on the opposite side.[4][2]

Benefits:

Vrksasana strengthens the muscles of the standing leg, ankle, and foot. The pose improves balance and neuromuscular coordination. Research suggests balancing poses like Vrksasana may reduce fall risk in older adults. Traditional yogic understanding associates the pose with mental steadiness and concentration.[9][8][4][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:

Primary muscles include the quadriceps, gluteus medius, and core stabilizers of the standing leg. Secondary muscles include hip adductors of the lifted leg, ankle stabilizers, and erector spinae. The vestibular and proprioceptive systems are actively engaged.[4][2]

Contraindications and Precautions:

Individuals with acute knee injuries should avoid placing the foot directly against the knee joint. Those with balance disorders or recent lower extremity injuries should practice near a wall. Individuals with high blood pressure should keep arms at heart level rather than overhead.[10][6][4]

Common Mistakes:

Common errors include allowing the standing knee to hyperextend or rotate inward. Practitioners often lean the torso toward the standing leg rather than maintaining vertical alignment. Placing the foot directly on the knee joint can create joint stress.[3][2][4]

Variations and Modifications:

Beginners may place the lifted foot against the ankle or lower calf with toes on the ground. Practitioners with balance challenges can practice near a wall for support. Advanced variations include closing the eyes or adding dynamic arm movements.[6][2]

Sources:

- Gheranda Samhita[8][1]

- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- NCCIH Yoga for Balance[4]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[3]

VIRABHADRASANA I

Sanskrit Name: Virabhadrasana I
English Name: Warrior Pose I
Meaning of Name: Named after Virabhadra, a fierce warrior in Hindu mythology[11]

Category: Standing Asana
Difficulty Level: Beginner to Intermediate

Description:
Virabhadrasana I is classified among standing asanas that build strength and stability. The pose combines hip flexion and extension with spinal extension and arm elevation. Light on Yoga describes this as a foundational warrior pose that develops leg strength and chest opening.[11][2][3]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin standing at the front of the mat in Tadasana. Step the left foot back approximately 3 to 4 feet, turning the left foot out 45 degrees. Square the hips toward the front of the mat by drawing the left hip forward. Bend the right knee to 90 degrees, ensuring the knee tracks over the second toe. Keep the left leg straight and strong. Raise both arms overhead with palms facing each other or joined. Draw the shoulder blades down the back while lifting the chest. Maintain the pose for 30 seconds to 1 minute with steady breathing, then repeat on the opposite side.[11][2][3]

Benefits:
Virabhadrasana I strengthens the quadriceps, gluteal muscles, and shoulder stabilizers. The pose stretches the hip flexors of the back leg and opens the chest. Regular practice may improve lower body strength and hip flexibility. Traditional yogic understanding associates warrior poses with courage and determination.[8][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary working muscles include the quadriceps and gluteus maximus of the front leg, hip flexors of the back leg, deltoids, and core stabilizers. Secondary muscles include the gastrocnemius and soleus of the

back leg, erector spinae, and shoulder girdle muscles. The cardiovascular system is moderately engaged during sustained holds.[2]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with knee injuries should avoid deep knee flexion or practice with reduced depth. Those with high blood pressure should keep arms at shoulder height rather than overhead. Individuals with shoulder injuries may keep hands at heart center. Pregnant women should practice with a wider stance for stability.[7][10][4]

Common Mistakes:
Common alignment errors include allowing the front knee to collapse inward rather than tracking over the second toe. Practitioners often fail to square the hips toward the front, reducing the stretch in the back hip flexor. Overarching the lower back instead of maintaining neutral spinal alignment creates unnecessary compression.[3][2]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners may reduce the depth of the front knee bend. Those with shoulder limitations can keep hands at heart center or on hips. Advanced practitioners may increase the back leg distance or add a backbend.[11][2]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[11][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- NCCIH Yoga Safety Guidelines[10][4]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[7]

VIRABHADRASANA II

Sanskrit Name: Virabhadrasana II
English Name: Warrior Pose II
Meaning of Name: Second variation of the warrior pose series[11]

Category: Standing Asana
Difficulty Level: Beginner to Intermediate

Description:

Virabhadrasana II is presented in Light on Yoga as a standing pose emphasizing lateral hip opening and arm extension. The posture requires external rotation of the front hip while maintaining internal rotation of the back hip. The pose develops both strength and flexibility simultaneously.[3][2][11]

Step-by-Step Practice:

Begin in Tadasana and step feet approximately 3 to 4 feet apart. Turn the right foot out 90 degrees and the left foot in slightly. Align the right heel with the arch of the left foot. Extend arms parallel to the floor at shoulder height with palms facing down. Bend the right knee to 90 degrees, ensuring the knee tracks over the second toe and does not extend beyond the ankle. Keep the torso vertical and centered between the legs. Turn the head to gaze over the right fingertips. Hold for 30 seconds to 1 minute with steady breathing, then repeat on the opposite side.[2][11][3]

Benefits:

Virabhadrasana II strengthens the quadriceps, gluteal muscles, and shoulder stabilizers. The pose opens the hips and groin while building leg endurance. Research on yoga suggests standing poses may improve lower body strength and balance. Traditional understanding associates the pose with focus and determination.[8][4][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:

Primary working muscles include the quadriceps and adductors of the front leg, abductors of the back leg, deltoids, and core stabilizers. Secondary muscles include the rotator cuff muscles, serratus anterior, and gluteal muscles. The cardiovascular system is engaged during sustained practice.[2]

Contraindications and Precautions:

Individuals with knee problems should avoid deep knee flexion or practice with reduced depth. Those with hip injuries should limit the range of hip external rotation. Individuals with neck problems should keep the gaze forward rather than turning the head. High blood pressure requires monitoring during sustained holds.[10][4]

Common Mistakes:

Common errors include allowing the front knee to collapse inward instead of tracking over the second toe. Practitioners often lean the torso toward the front leg rather than maintaining vertical alignment. Raising the shoulders toward the ears creates unnecessary tension.[3][2]

Variations and Modifications:

Beginners may reduce the depth of the knee bend or decrease the stance width. Those with knee concerns

can practice with the front knee at a less acute angle. Advanced practitioners may lower into a deeper squat or add arm variations.[11][2]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[11][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[10][4]

UTTHITA TRIKONASANA

Sanskrit Name: Utthita Trikonasana
English Name: Extended Triangle Pose
Meaning of Name: Utthita means extended, trikona means triangle[11]

Category: Standing Asana
Difficulty Level: Beginner to Intermediate

Description:
Utthita Trikonasana is described in Light on Yoga as a fundamental standing pose that creates a triangular shape with the body. The asana combines lateral flexion of the spine with hip opening and rotation. The pose emphasizes length through the sides of the body.[3][2][11]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin in Tadasana and step feet approximately 3 to 4 feet apart. Turn the right foot out 90 degrees and the left foot in 15 degrees. Align the right heel with the arch of the left foot. Extend arms parallel to the floor at shoulder height. Shift the hips to the left as the torso extends to the right. Lower the right hand to the right shin, ankle, or floor while extending the left arm upward. Keep both legs straight and engaged. Rotate the chest toward the ceiling and gaze up at the left thumb if comfortable for the neck. Hold for 30 seconds to 1 minute with steady breathing, then repeat on the opposite side.[3][2][11]

Benefits:
Utthita Trikonasana stretches the hamstrings, hips, and lateral torso muscles. The pose strengthens the legs, core, and ankle stabilizers. Research suggests standing poses may improve balance and lower body strength. Traditional yogic understanding attributes the pose with improving digestion and reducing stress, though scientific evidence for these claims is limited.[5][4][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary lengthening muscles include the hamstrings, tensor fasciae latae, external obliques, and intercostals of the lower side. Working muscles include the quadriceps, gluteal muscles, core stabilizers, and shoulder stabilizers. The proprioceptive system is engaged to maintain balance.[4][2]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with low blood pressure should avoid the full depth of the forward fold. Those with neck problems should keep the gaze forward or down rather than upward. Individuals with diarrhea or headache should practice with caution. High blood pressure requires modified practice with reduced intensity.[10][4]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include bending the front knee, which reduces the hamstring stretch and creates instability. Practitioners often allow the hips to rotate forward rather than keeping them aligned in the frontal plane. Collapsing the chest toward the floor instead of rotating it upward diminishes the spinal rotation component.[2][3]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners may place the bottom hand on a block for support. Those with tight hamstrings can keep the bottom hand higher on the leg. Advanced practitioners may bind the hands behind the back or lower the bottom hand to the floor.[11][2]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[3][11]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[10][4]

UTKATASANA

Sanskrit Name: Utkatasana
English Name: Chair Pose or Fierce Pose
Meaning of Name: Utkata means fierce, powerful, or intense[1][8]

Category: Standing Asana
Difficulty Level: Beginner to Intermediate

Description:

Utkatasana is described in the Gheranda Samhita as a pose engaging lower body strength. The posture combines hip and knee flexion with spinal extension and arm elevation. The asana challenges muscular endurance and cardiovascular stamina.[1][8][2]

Step-by-Step Practice:

Begin in Tadasana with feet hip-width apart. Inhale and raise the arms overhead, keeping them parallel or with palms together. Exhale and bend the knees as if sitting back into an imaginary chair. Lower the hips until the thighs are approximately parallel to the floor, ensuring the knees do not extend beyond the toes. Keep the torso slightly forward but the chest lifted. Engage the core muscles and maintain steady breathing. Hold for 30 seconds to 1 minute, then return to Tadasana.[11][3][2]

Benefits:

Utkatasana strengthens the quadriceps, gluteal muscles, and core stabilizers. The pose builds muscular endurance in the lower body. Research suggests standing poses may improve functional fitness and lower body strength. Traditional yogic texts describe the pose as building resilience and mental fortitude.[1][8][4][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:

Primary working muscles include the quadriceps, gluteus maximus, core stabilizers, and deltoids. Secondary muscles include the gastrocnemius, soleus, erector spinae, and hip stabilizers. The cardiovascular system is moderately to significantly engaged.[2]

Contraindications and Precautions:

Individuals with knee problems should limit the depth of knee flexion. Those with chronic headaches or insomnia should practice with arms at heart level rather than overhead. Individuals with low blood pressure may experience dizziness and should practice with caution. Pregnant women should practice with a wider stance and reduced depth.[7][4][10]

Common Mistakes:

Common errors include allowing the knees to collapse inward rather than tracking over the second and third toes. Practitioners often shift weight onto the toes instead of keeping it in the heels. Arching the lower back excessively creates spinal compression.[3][2]

Variations and Modifications:

Beginners may reduce the depth of the squat or practice with a wall behind them for support. Those with shoulder limitations can keep hands at heart center. Advanced practitioners may lift the heels or twist the torso.[11][2]

Sources:

- Gheranda Samhita[8][1]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[3][11]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[4][10]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[7]

GARUDASANA

Sanskrit Name: Garudasana
English Name: Eagle Pose
Meaning of Name: Garuda refers to a mythical eagle in Hindu tradition[1][8]

Category: Standing Asana, Balancing
Difficulty Level: Intermediate

Description:
Garudasana is described in the Gheranda Samhita as enhancing coordination and concentration. The pose combines balance with binding of the arms and legs. Light on Yoga presents this asana as developing focus and joint flexibility.[8][1][11][3][2]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin in Tadasana and shift weight onto the right foot. Bend both knees slightly and lift the left foot. Cross the left thigh over the right thigh and hook the left foot behind the right calf if possible. Extend the arms forward at shoulder height and cross the right arm over the left. Bend the elbows and bring the palms together, or place the backs of the hands together. Sink the hips lower while keeping the standing leg's knee tracking forward. Hold for 30 seconds to 1 minute with steady breathing, then repeat on the opposite side.[3][2]

Benefits:
Garudasana strengthens the ankles and improves balance. The pose stretches the shoulders, upper back, and outer hips. Research suggests balancing poses may improve neuromuscular coordination. Traditional understanding associates the pose with enhanced concentration.[1][8][4][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary working muscles include the gluteus medius and minimus, quadriceps of the standing leg, and ankle stabilizers. Lengthening muscles include the rhomboids, posterior deltoids, and external hip rotators. The proprioceptive and vestibular systems are highly engaged.[4][2]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with knee injuries should avoid the full binding of the legs. Those with shoulder injuries may keep the arms unbound. Individuals with balance disorders should practice near a wall or chair. High blood pressure requires monitoring during practice.[6][10][4]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include leaning the torso forward excessively, which compromises balance. Practitioners often fail to sink the hips, reducing the strengthening benefit. Forcing the foot bind when flexibility is insufficient can strain the knee.[4][2][3]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners may practice without binding the foot or arms. Those with balance challenges can practice near a wall. Advanced practitioners may add a forward fold or other arm variations.[6][11][2]

Sources:

- Gheranda Samhita[8][1]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[11][3]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[6][10][4]

2. SITTING ASANAS

SUKHASANA

Sanskrit Name: Sukhasana
English Name: Easy Pose
Meaning of Name: Sukha means ease, comfort, or happiness[1]

Category: Sitting Asana
Difficulty Level: Beginner

Description:

Sukhasana is described in classical texts as a comfortable seated position for meditation and pranayama practice. The pose involves simple cross-legged sitting with an upright spine. Traditional teachings emphasize this as an accessible alternative to more complex seated postures.[8][1][2]

Step-by-Step Practice:

Begin by sitting on the floor or a folded blanket with legs extended forward. Bend the knees and cross the right shin in front of the left, bringing each foot beneath the opposite knee. Rest the hands on the knees with palms facing up or down. Lengthen the spine upward from the pelvis through the crown of the head. Relax the shoulders away from the ears. Maintain natural breathing and hold for 1 to 5 minutes or longer for meditation practice. Alternate which leg crosses in front to maintain balance.[3][2]

Benefits:

Sukhasana opens the hips and stretches the outer thighs and ankles. The pose strengthens the back and promotes upright postural alignment. Research on meditation suggests comfortable seated positions support sustained practice. Traditional understanding associates seated poses with calming the mind and preparing for pranayama.[1][8][4][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:

Primary lengthening muscles include the hip external rotators and adductors. Working muscles include the erector spinae, quadratus lumborum, and core stabilizers. The parasympathetic nervous system may be activated during prolonged holds with conscious breathing.[4][2]

Contraindications and Precautions:

Individuals with knee injuries should practice with elevated hips or extended legs. Those with hip injuries may require additional support under the knees. Individuals with sciatica should practice with caution and elevate the hips.[4]

Common Mistakes:

Common errors include rounding the back, which compresses the spine and restricts breathing. Practitioners often sit directly on the floor when elevated hips would better support spinal alignment. Tensing the shoulders or jaw contradicts the ease implied by the pose name.[2][3]

Variations and Modifications:

Beginners should sit on folded blankets or a cushion to elevate the hips above the knees. Those with knee discomfort can place support under the knees. Advanced practitioners may practice for extended periods during meditation.[1][2]

Sources:

- Gheranda Samhita[8][1]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[3]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[4]

PADMASANA

Sanskrit Name: Padmasana
English Name: Lotus Pose
Meaning of Name: Padma means lotus flower[8][1]

Category: Sitting Asana
Difficulty Level: Advanced

Description:
Padmasana is described in the Hatha Yoga Pradipika and Gheranda Samhita as one of the most important meditation seats. The Gheranda Samhita states this is a posture that eradicates many diseases. The pose requires significant hip external rotation and knee flexibility.[12][13][1][8][2]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin seated with legs extended forward. Bend the right knee and bring the right foot to rest on top of the left thigh with the sole facing upward. Bend the left knee and bring the left foot to rest on top of the right thigh with the sole facing upward. Both knees should rest on the floor. Rest the hands on the knees in a mudra or with palms facing up. Lengthen the spine and maintain natural breathing. Hold for 1 to 5 minutes or as comfortable, then carefully release.[13][1][2]

Benefits:
Padmasana opens the hips and stretches the ankles and knees. Traditional yogic texts describe the pose as promoting deep meditation and energy conservation. The Gheranda Samhita attributes disease prevention to regular practice, though scientific evidence for therapeutic benefits is limited.[13][1][8][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary lengthening muscles include the hip external rotators, adductors, and ankle dorsiflexors. Working

muscles include the erector spinae and core stabilizers. The pose is traditionally associated with regulation of pranic energy.[13][1][2]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with knee or ankle injuries should avoid this pose. Those with hip limitations should practice simpler seated poses. The NCCIH recommends that beginners avoid extreme practices such as the lotus position. Forcing the legs into position can cause serious knee injury.[6][4]

Common Mistakes:
The most serious error is forcing the knees or ankles into position without adequate hip flexibility. Practitioners often attempt the full pose before developing sufficient external hip rotation. Rounding the spine negates the postural benefits.[6][4][3][2]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners should practice Sukhasana or half lotus (Ardha Padmasana) instead. Adequate hip opening through preparatory poses is essential before attempting full Padmasana. Sitting on elevation supports spinal alignment.[3][2]

Sources:

- Hatha Yoga Pradipika[12][13]
- Gheranda Samhita[1][8]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[3]
- NCCIH Yoga Safety[6][4]

VAJRASANA

Sanskrit Name: Vajrasana
English Name: Thunderbolt Pose or Diamond Pose
Meaning of Name: Vajra means thunderbolt or diamond, representing strength[8][1]

Category: Sitting Asana, Kneeling
Difficulty Level: Beginner

Description:

Vajrasana is described in the Gheranda Samhita as bestowing psychic abilities to the practitioner. The pose involves kneeling with the hips resting on the heels. Traditional texts recommend this posture for pranayama practice and post-meal sitting.[1][8][2]

Step-by-Step Practice:

Begin by kneeling on the floor with knees together or slightly apart. Point the toes backward and sit on the heels, resting the buttocks between the heels. Place the hands on the thighs with palms facing down. Lengthen the spine upward and relax the shoulders. Maintain natural breathing and hold for 1 to 5 minutes. To release, lean forward slightly and extend the legs.[2][3]

Benefits:

Vajrasana stretches the quadriceps, ankles, and tops of the feet. The pose is commonly practiced to support digestion after meals in traditional yogic practice. Regular practice may improve postural awareness. Traditional understanding attributes the development of mental stillness to sustained practice.[8][1][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:

Primary lengthening muscles include the quadriceps, tibialis anterior, and ankle plantar flexors. Working muscles include the erector spinae and core stabilizers. Traditional texts suggest the pose influences digestive system function.[1][8][2]

Contraindications and Precautions:

Individuals with knee injuries or knee pain should avoid this pose or use significant cushioning. Those with ankle injuries should practice with caution or avoid the pose. Individuals with varicose veins should limit the duration of practice.[4]

Common Mistakes:

Common errors include forcing the hips to the heels when knee or ankle flexibility is insufficient. Practitioners often round the back rather than maintaining spinal length. Tensing the feet or ankles creates unnecessary discomfort.[3][2]

Variations and Modifications:

Beginners should place a folded blanket between the buttocks and heels for support. Those with ankle discomfort can place a rolled towel under the ankles. Individuals with knee concerns may place additional padding under the knees.[2]

Sources:

- Gheranda Samhita[8][1]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[3]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[4]

BADDHA KONASANA

Sanskrit Name: Baddha Konasana
English Name: Bound Angle Pose or Butterfly Pose
Meaning of Name: Baddha means bound, kona means angle[11]

Category: Sitting Asana
Difficulty Level: Beginner to Intermediate

Description:
Baddha Konasana is presented in Light on Yoga as a seated hip-opening posture. The pose involves bringing the soles of the feet together while seated. The asana is frequently included in preparatory sequences for more advanced hip-opening poses.[11][3][2]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin seated with legs extended forward. Bend the knees and bring the soles of the feet together, allowing the knees to fall outward. Draw the heels as close to the pelvis as comfortable. Hold the feet or ankles with the hands. Lengthen the spine upward and gently press the thighs toward the floor without forcing. Maintain natural breathing and hold for 1 to 5 minutes. To deepen the stretch, hinge forward from the hips while maintaining spinal length.[11][3][2]

Benefits:
Baddha Konasana stretches the inner thighs, groins, and hip external rotators. The pose may improve hip flexibility and reduce tightness in the pelvic region. Research suggests hip-opening poses are commonly included in prenatal yoga programs. Traditional understanding associates the pose with reproductive health, though scientific evidence is limited.[5][7][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary lengthening muscles include the adductors, hip external rotators, and pelvic floor muscles. Working muscles include the erector spinae, hip flexors, and core stabilizers. The pose may influence circulation to the pelvic region.[2]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with groin or hip injuries should practice with support under the knees. Those with knee injuries should avoid pressing the knees toward the floor. Individuals with sacroiliac joint dysfunction should practice with caution.[4]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include rounding the back, especially when folding forward. Practitioners often force the knees downward rather than allowing gravity and breath to create gradual opening. Tensing the shoulders or jaw reduces the relaxation benefit.[3][2]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners should sit on a folded blanket to elevate the hips and support spinal alignment. Placing blocks or folded blankets under the knees provides support for tight hips. Advanced practitioners may fold forward more deeply or hold the pose for extended periods.[11][2]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[11][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[4]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[7]

GOMUKHASANA

Sanskrit Name: Gomukhasana
English Name: Cow Face Pose
Meaning of Name: Go means cow, mukha means face[1][8]

Category: Sitting Asana
Difficulty Level: Intermediate

Description:
Gomukhasana is described in the Gheranda Samhita as enhancing flexibility and balance. The pose combines hip stacking with a shoulder and arm bind. The asana challenges both lower and upper body flexibility simultaneously.[8][1][2]

Step-by-Step Practice:

Begin seated with legs extended forward. Bend the right knee and place the right foot outside the left hip. Bend the left knee and stack the left knee directly over the right knee, bringing the left foot outside the right hip. Sit evenly on both sitting bones. Extend the right arm overhead, bend the elbow, and bring the right hand down the back. Extend the left arm to the side, bend the elbow, and bring the left hand up the back. If possible, clasp the fingers behind the back. Hold for 30 seconds to 1 minute with steady breathing, then repeat on the opposite side.[11][3][2]

Benefits:

Gomukhasana stretches the hips, thighs, shoulders, chest, and triceps. The pose may improve shoulder mobility and hip flexibility. Research suggests stretching exercises may reduce joint stiffness. Traditional yogic understanding associates the pose with improved circulation.[1][8][4][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:

Primary lengthening muscles include the hip external rotators, tensor fasciae latae, pectoralis major, triceps, and shoulder external rotators. Working muscles include the erector spinae, core stabilizers, and scapular stabilizers. Multiple joint systems are simultaneously engaged.[2]

Contraindications and Precautions:

Individuals with knee injuries should avoid the leg position or use modifications. Those with shoulder injuries should avoid the arm bind or use a strap. Individuals with hip injuries should practice with caution.[4]

Common Mistakes:

Common errors include leaning to one side rather than sitting evenly on both sitting bones. Practitioners often force the shoulder bind without adequate flexibility. Rounding the back reduces the chest opening benefit.[3][2]

Variations and Modifications:

Beginners should use a strap between the hands if they cannot clasp. Those with knee concerns can extend the bottom leg or sit on a block. The arm and leg components can be practiced separately.[2]

Sources:

- Gheranda Samhita[8][1]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[11][3]

- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[4]

DANDASANA

Sanskrit Name: Dandasana
English Name: Staff Pose
Meaning of Name: Danda means staff or stick[11]

Category: Sitting Asana
Difficulty Level: Beginner

Description:
Dandasana is presented in Light on Yoga as the foundational seated pose for forward bends. The asana emphasizes active engagement while seated with legs extended. The pose serves as a starting position for numerous seated asanas.[11][3][2]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin seated with legs extended forward and together. Flex the feet with toes pointing toward the ceiling. Press the thighs firmly into the floor and engage the quadriceps. Place the hands beside the hips with fingers pointing forward, pressing into the floor. Lengthen the spine upward from the pelvis through the crown of the head. Draw the shoulder blades down the back and lift the chest. Maintain steady breathing and hold for 30 seconds to 1 minute.[3][2]

Benefits:
Dandasana strengthens the back muscles and core stabilizers. The pose stretches the hamstrings and improves postural awareness. Regular practice may support spinal alignment. The asana is commonly used to establish proper alignment before transitioning to other seated poses.[11][3][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary working muscles include the erector spinae, quadriceps, core stabilizers, and triceps. Lengthening muscles include the hamstrings and gastrocnemius. The proprioceptive system is engaged to maintain vertical spinal alignment.[4][2]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with lower back injuries should practice with the back against a wall. Those with tight hamstrings should sit on a folded blanket and may bend the knees slightly. Individuals with wrist injuries should modify hand placement.[4][2]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include rounding the back, which defeats the postural strengthening purpose. Practitioners often lean back rather than maintaining vertical spinal alignment. Hyperextending the knees creates joint stress.[3][2]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners should sit on a folded blanket to elevate the hips and facilitate spinal length. Those with tight hamstrings can slightly bend the knees. Hands can be placed on blocks beside the hips if needed.[2]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[11][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[4]

3. SUPINE ASANAS

SAVASANA

Sanskrit Name: Savasana
English Name: Corpse Pose
Meaning of Name: Sava means corpse[11]

Category: Supine Asana, Relaxation
Difficulty Level: Beginner

Description:
Savasana is described in classical texts and modern teaching as the fundamental relaxation pose. Light on Yoga presents this asana as essential for integration and recovery. The pose involves conscious relaxation in a supine position.[3][11][2]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Lie on the back with legs extended and separated slightly wider than hip-width. Allow the feet to fall naturally outward. Place the arms alongside the body with palms facing up, several inches from the torso. Close the eyes and systematically relax each body part from feet to head. Allow the breath to become

natural and effortless. Remain in the pose for 5 to 15 minutes. To exit, deepen the breath, bring awareness back to the body, and roll to one side before sitting up.[3][2]

Benefits:

Savasana promotes deep relaxation and stress reduction. Research suggests relaxation practices may reduce anxiety and improve sleep quality. The pose allows the nervous system to integrate the benefits of preceding practices. Studies indicate yoga-based relaxation may activate the parasympathetic nervous system.[4][3]

Muscles and Systems Involved:

All muscles are passively relaxed with minimal engagement. The parasympathetic nervous system becomes predominant. The pose supports physiological rest and recovery.[4][2]

Contraindications and Precautions:

Pregnant women after the first trimester should avoid lying flat on the back for extended periods. Side-lying position is recommended for prenatal practice. Individuals with lower back discomfort can place a bolster under the knees.[7][4][2]

Common Mistakes:

Common challenges include mental restlessness and difficulty maintaining stillness. Practitioners often tense muscles unconsciously rather than achieving complete relaxation. Rushing the exit from the pose disrupts the integration process.[3][2]

Variations and Modifications:

Those with lower back discomfort should place support under the knees. Pregnant women should lie on the left side with support between the knees. A blanket over the body helps maintain warmth and comfort.[7][2]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[11][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- NCCIH Yoga Benefits[4]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[7]

SUPTA BADDHA KONASANA

Sanskrit Name: Supta Baddha Konasana
English Name: Reclined Bound Angle Pose
Meaning of Name: Supta means reclined, baddha means bound, kona means angle[11]

Category: Supine Asana, Restorative
Difficulty Level: Beginner

Description:
Supta Baddha Konasana is presented in Light on Yoga as a restorative variation of Baddha Konasana. The supine position allows gravity to assist hip opening while reducing muscular effort. The pose is commonly included in restorative and prenatal yoga sequences.[7][3][11][2]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin seated in Baddha Konasana with soles of feet together. Slowly lower the back to the floor, using the hands for support. Rest the arms alongside the body with palms facing up or place hands on the abdomen. Allow the knees to fall outward with gravity. Support can be placed under the knees if the hip opening is intense. Maintain natural breathing and hold for 3 to 10 minutes. To exit, use the hands to bring the knees together before rolling to one side.[3][2]

Benefits:
Supta Baddha Konasana gently opens the hips and groin. The pose may reduce stress and promote relaxation. Research suggests restorative poses may improve sleep quality. The asana is commonly included in prenatal yoga for pelvic opening.[7][4][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary lengthening muscles include the adductors and hip external rotators. The parasympathetic nervous system may be activated during sustained holds. Minimal muscular effort is required in this restorative variation.[4][2]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Pregnant women after the first trimester should elevate the upper body significantly or practice side-lying variations. Individuals with hip or groin injuries should use adequate support under the knees. Those with lower back discomfort should place a bolster under the torso.[7][4][2]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include forcing the knees toward the floor, which creates strain. Practitioners often omit support when flexibility is limited. Lying completely flat may strain the lower back in some individuals.[3][2]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners should place blocks or folded blankets under each knee for support. A bolster under the spine elevates the upper body and reduces lower back strain. Pregnant women should use significant upper body elevation.[7][2]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[11][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- NCCIH Yoga Benefits[4]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[7]

SETU BANDHA SARVANGASANA

Sanskrit Name: Setu Bandha Sarvangasana
English Name: Bridge Pose
Meaning of Name: Setu means bridge, bandha means bind or lock[11]

Category: Supine Asana, Backbend
Difficulty Level: Beginner to Intermediate

Description:
Setu Bandha Sarvangasana is presented in Light on Yoga as a foundational backbend performed from a supine position. The pose combines hip extension, spinal extension, and shoulder opening. The asana serves as preparation for more advanced backbends.[3][2][11]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Lie on the back with knees bent and feet hip-width apart, heels close to the sitting bones. Press the feet firmly into the floor and engage the gluteal muscles. Lift the hips toward the ceiling, creating a diagonal line from knees to shoulders. Interlace the fingers beneath the back and press the arms into the floor. Draw the shoulder blades toward each other and lift the chest toward the chin. Maintain steady breathing and hold for 30 seconds to 1 minute. To release, unlock the hands and slowly lower the spine to the floor.[2][11][3]

Benefits:
Setu Bandha Sarvangasana strengthens the gluteal muscles, hamstrings, and back extensors. The pose

stretches the hip flexors, chest, and anterior neck. Research suggests backbending poses may improve spinal flexibility. Traditional understanding associates the pose with energizing effects.[4][3][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary working muscles include the gluteus maximus, hamstrings, erector spinae, and posterior shoulder muscles. Lengthening muscles include the hip flexors, pectoralis major, and anterior neck muscles. The pose engages the core stabilizers to protect the lower back.[2]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with neck injuries should avoid pressing the chin toward the chest. Those with lower back pain should practice with reduced hip elevation. Individuals with knee problems should ensure proper knee tracking.[4]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include allowing the knees to splay outward or inward rather than tracking over the second toe. Practitioners often overarch the lower back instead of evenly distributing the backbend through the spine. Tensing the gluteal muscles excessively can create cramping.[3][2]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners can practice with feet slightly wider than hip-width. A block can be placed under the sacrum for a supported, restorative variation. Advanced practitioners may lift one leg toward the ceiling.[11][2]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[11][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[4]

SUPTA PADANGUSTHASANA

Sanskrit Name: Supta Padangusthasana
English Name: Reclined Hand-to-Big-Toe Pose
Meaning of Name: Supta means reclined, pada means foot, angustha means big toe[11]

Category: Supine Asana
Difficulty Level: Beginner to Intermediate

Description:

Supta Padangusthasana is described in Light on Yoga as a supine hamstring stretch. The pose isolates hamstring lengthening while supporting the back on the floor. The asana is commonly used therapeutically for lower back care.[4][3][2][11]

Step-by-Step Practice:

Lie on the back with both legs extended. Bend the right knee and bring the thigh toward the chest. Loop a strap around the ball of the right foot or hold the big toe with the first two fingers and thumb. Straighten the right leg toward the ceiling, keeping the left leg extended on the floor. Press the left thigh down and flex the left foot. Hold for 1 to 3 minutes with steady breathing, then repeat on the opposite side. Variations include taking the raised leg across the body or out to the side.[3][2][11]

Benefits:

Supta Padangusthasana stretches the hamstrings, calves, and hip muscles. The pose may alleviate lower back tension by reducing hamstring tightness. Research on yoga for low back pain includes poses that address hamstring flexibility. The supine position reduces strain on the lower back during stretching.[4][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:

Primary lengthening muscles include the hamstrings, gastrocnemius, and hip adductors or abductors depending on variation. Working muscles include the hip flexors of the raised leg and quadriceps. The pose gently engages core stabilizers.[2]

Contraindications and Precautions:

Individuals with hamstring injuries should practice gently without forcing the stretch. Those with high blood pressure should avoid holding the breath during the stretch. Individuals with lower back injuries should keep the bottom leg slightly bent if needed.[10][4]

Common Mistakes:

Common errors include lifting the lower back off the floor, which reduces the effectiveness of the hamstring stretch. Practitioners often force the raised leg toward the face without maintaining proper alignment. Tensing the shoulders or neck creates unnecessary discomfort.[3][2]

Variations and Modifications:

Beginners should use a strap around the foot and bend the raised leg as needed. Those with tight hamstrings can bend the bottom leg. Advanced practitioners may hold the big toe directly and straighten both legs completely.[11][2]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[3][11]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- NCCIH Yoga for Low Back Pain[10][4]

ANANDA BALASANA

Sanskrit Name: Ananda Balasana
English Name: Happy Baby Pose
Meaning of Name: Ananda means bliss or happiness, bala means child[2]

Category: Supine Asana
Difficulty Level: Beginner

Description:
Ananda Balasana is presented in modern yoga teaching as a gentle hip-opening pose that mimics the position of a happy infant. The supine position allows for safe exploration of hip flexibility. The pose combines hip flexion with external rotation.[2]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Lie on the back and bring both knees toward the chest. Separate the knees wider than the torso. Reach the hands to hold the outside edges of the feet or around the ankles. Flex the feet with soles facing the ceiling. Gently draw the knees toward the armpits while keeping the back flat on the floor. Maintain natural breathing and hold for 1 to 3 minutes. To release, bring the knees together and lower the feet to the floor.[2]

Benefits:
Ananda Balasana stretches the inner thighs, groin, and hip muscles. The pose gently decompresses the spine and lower back. Research suggests gentle yoga poses may reduce stress and promote relaxation. The playful nature of the pose may enhance mood.[4][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary lengthening muscles include the adductors, hip external rotators, and gluteal muscles. The pose involves minimal muscular effort with passive stretching. The parasympathetic nervous system may be activated.[4][2]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Pregnant women should practice with knees wide to accommodate the abdomen or avoid the pose in later pregnancy. Individuals with knee injuries should modify hand placement to the thighs or shins. Those with neck problems should ensure the head rests comfortably on the floor.[7][4]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include lifting the tailbone off the floor, which reduces the lower back release. Practitioners often force the knees down rather than allowing gradual opening. Tensing the shoulders or neck contradicts the relaxation purpose.[3][2]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners can hold the backs of the thighs or shins instead of the feet. A strap can be looped around each foot if reaching the feet is difficult. The pose can be practiced with one leg at a time.[2]

Sources:

- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[3]
- NCCIH Yoga Benefits[4]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[7]

APANASANA

Sanskrit Name: Apanasana
English Name: Knees-to-Chest Pose or Wind-Relieving Pose
Meaning of Name: Apana refers to downward-moving energy or elimination[2]

Category: Supine Asana
Difficulty Level: Beginner

Description:
Apanasana is taught in modern yoga as a gentle pose for lower back release and digestive support. The supine position with knees drawn to chest creates gentle spinal flexion. The pose is commonly used as a counter-pose to backbends.[3][2]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Lie on the back with both knees bent and feet flat on the floor. Draw both knees toward the chest. Hold the

shins or wrap the arms around the knees. Allow the lower back to gently round and press into the floor. The head may remain on the floor or lift slightly toward the knees. Rock gently side to side to massage the back if comfortable. Hold for 1 to 3 minutes with natural breathing.[2]

Benefits:

Apanasana gently releases tension in the lower back muscles. The pose may promote relaxation and digestion according to traditional understanding, though scientific evidence is limited. Research on yoga suggests gentle movements may reduce lower back discomfort. The rocking motion provides gentle spinal massage.[5][4][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:

Primary lengthening muscles include the erector spinae and lower back muscles. The hip flexors and abdominal muscles are gently engaged. Traditional teachings suggest the pose influences digestive function.[5][2]

Contraindications and Precautions:

Pregnant women in later pregnancy should practice with knees wide or avoid the pose. Individuals with hip or knee injuries should modify the depth of knee flexion. Those with neck problems should keep the head on the floor.[7][4]

Common Mistakes:

Common errors include forcing the knees too close to the chest, which can strain the hips. Practitioners often tense the shoulders and neck rather than maintaining relaxation. Holding the breath reduces the relaxation benefit.[3][2]

Variations and Modifications:

Beginners can practice with one knee at a time. A blanket under the head provides additional neck support. The gentle rocking motion can be added or omitted based on comfort.[2]

Sources:

- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[3]
- NCCIH Yoga for Low Back Pain[4]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[7]

4. PRONE ASANAS

BHUJANGASANA

Sanskrit Name: Bhujangasana
English Name: Cobra Pose
Meaning of Name: Bhujanga means serpent or snake[1][8]

Category: Prone Asana, Backbend
Difficulty Level: Beginner to Intermediate

Description:
Bhujangasana is described in the Gheranda Samhita as awakening dormant energy and enhancing spinal flexibility. The classical text states the pose raises core temperature consistently and eliminates all illnesses. Light on Yoga presents this as a foundational backbend performed from a prone position.[8][1][11][3]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Lie prone with the forehead on the floor and legs extended back. Place the hands beneath the shoulders with elbows close to the ribs. Press the tops of the feet and thighs firmly into the floor. Inhale and lift the chest forward and upward, straightening the arms partially or completely depending on flexibility. Keep the elbows slightly bent and shoulders drawn away from the ears. Engage the back muscles rather than relying solely on arm strength. Hold for 15 to 30 seconds with steady breathing, then release.[3][2]

Benefits:
Bhujangasana strengthens the spinal extensors and posterior shoulder muscles. The pose stretches the chest, abdominals, and hip flexors. Research suggests backbending poses may improve spinal flexibility. Traditional texts attribute energy awakening and disease prevention to the pose, though scientific evidence for these claims is limited.[1][8][4][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary working muscles include the erector spinae, quadratus lumborum, rhomboids, and posterior deltoids. Lengthening muscles include the rectus abdominis, hip flexors, and pectoralis major. The pose engages the gluteal muscles to protect the lower back.[2]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with lower back injuries should practice with minimal height or avoid the pose. Pregnant

women should avoid prone positions after the first trimester. Those with wrist injuries should modify hand placement or practice on forearms.[7][4]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include lifting too high too quickly, which compresses the lower back. Practitioners often use excessive arm strength rather than engaging the back muscles. Allowing the shoulders to hunch toward the ears reduces the chest opening.[3][2]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners should keep the elbows bent and maintain a gentle backbend. Those with lower back sensitivity can keep the hands further forward. Advanced practitioners may straighten the arms completely or add variations.[11][2]

Sources:

- Gheranda Samhita[8][1]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[11][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[4]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[7]

SALABHASANA

Sanskrit Name: Salabhasana
English Name: Locust Pose
Meaning of Name: Salabha means locust or grasshopper[1][8]

Category: Prone Asana, Backbend
Difficulty Level: Intermediate

Description:
Salabhasana is described in the Gheranda Samhita as strengthening the back and core muscles. The pose involves lifting the legs, chest, and arms from a prone position. Light on Yoga presents multiple variations of this strengthening backbend.[8][1][11][2]

Step-by-Step Practice:

Lie prone with the forehead on the floor and arms alongside the body with palms facing up or down. Engage the legs and press the tops of the feet into the floor. Inhale and simultaneously lift the head, chest, arms, and legs off the floor. Keep the gaze forward and avoid compressing the back of the neck. Reach back through the legs and forward through the chest. Hold for 15 to 30 seconds with steady breathing, then release.[11][3][2]

Benefits:

Salabhasana strengthens the erector spinae, gluteal muscles, hamstrings, and posterior shoulder muscles. The pose may improve postural endurance and back strength. Research suggests strengthening exercises may reduce lower back pain. Traditional texts attribute the pose with building core strength.[1][8][4][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:

Primary working muscles include the entire posterior chain: erector spinae, gluteus maximus, hamstrings, posterior deltoids, rhomboids, and trapezius. The pose requires significant core stabilization. The cardiovascular system is moderately engaged during sustained holds.[2]

Contraindications and Precautions:

Individuals with lower back injuries should practice with caution or avoid the pose. Pregnant women should avoid prone positions after the first trimester. Those with neck injuries should keep the forehead on the floor.[7][4]

Common Mistakes:

Common errors include lifting the legs higher than the torso can support, creating lower back compression. Practitioners often compress the back of the neck by looking too far upward. Holding the breath reduces oxygen supply and increases strain.[3][2]

Variations and Modifications:

Beginners can lift only the upper body or only the lower body. Arms can be extended forward instead of alongside the body. Advanced practitioners can increase the duration or add dynamic movements.[11][2]

Sources:

- Gheranda Samhita[8][1]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[11][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- NCCIH Yoga for Low Back Pain[4]

- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[7]

DHANURASANA

Sanskrit Name: Dhanurasana
English Name: Bow Pose
Meaning of Name: Dhanu means bow[1][8]

Category: Prone Asana, Backbend
Difficulty Level: Intermediate to Advanced

Description:
Dhanurasana is described in the Gheranda Samhita as enhancing spinal flexibility and energy flow. The pose creates a bow shape by simultaneously lifting the chest and legs while holding the ankles. Light on Yoga presents this as an intense backbend requiring strength and flexibility.[8][1][11][3][2]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Lie prone with the chin or forehead on the floor. Bend both knees and reach back to hold the outer ankles. Inhale and simultaneously lift the chest and kick the feet into the hands, raising the thighs off the floor. The body weight rests on the abdomen. Keep the knees approximately hip-width apart. Breathe steadily and hold for 15 to 30 seconds, then release.[11][3][2]

Benefits:
Dhanurasana strengthens the back extensors and opens the chest, shoulders, and hip flexors. The pose may improve spinal flexibility. Traditional texts associate the pose with improved energy and vitality. Research on yoga backbends is limited but suggests potential benefits for spinal mobility.[1][8][4][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary working muscles include the erector spinae, gluteal muscles, hamstrings, and quadriceps. Lengthening muscles include the rectus abdominis, hip flexors, pectoralis major, and anterior deltoids. The pose significantly engages the entire posterior chain.[2]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with lower back injuries should avoid this intense backbend. Pregnant women should avoid prone positions after the first trimester. Those with high blood pressure, heart disease, or abdominal surgery should avoid the pose. Individuals with neck injuries should practice with caution.[10][7][4]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include allowing the knees to splay wide apart, which creates strain. Practitioners often compress the lower back by lifting without adequate back strength. Holding the breath increases blood pressure and reduces benefits.[10][3][2]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners can practice holding one ankle at a time. A strap can be looped around the ankles if reaching them is difficult. Advanced practitioners may add rocking movements.[11][2]

Sources:

- Gheranda Samhita[8][1]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[11][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[10][4]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[7]

MAKARASANA

Sanskrit Name: Makarasana
English Name: Crocodile Pose
Meaning of Name: Makara means crocodile[1][8]

Category: Prone Asana, Relaxation
Difficulty Level: Beginner

Description:
Makarasana is described in the Gheranda Samhita as inducing deep rest and relaxation. The classical text states the pose raises core temperature. The asana involves resting prone with the head on folded arms.[8][1][2]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Lie prone with the legs extended and feet mat-width apart. Stack the hands and rest the forehead on the hands, or turn the head to one side. Allow the entire body to release and relax into the floor. The breath may be directed into the back body. Hold for 3 to 10 minutes, periodically changing the head position if needed.[2]

Benefits:

Makarasana promotes deep relaxation and recovery. The prone position may reduce stress on the back in some individuals. Research suggests relaxation poses may activate the parasympathetic nervous system. The pose allows observation of breath movement in the posterior torso.[1][8][4][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:

All muscles are passively relaxed. The parasympathetic nervous system is activated. The pose provides a different resting position than supine Savasana.[4][2]

Contraindications and Precautions:

Pregnant women should avoid prone positions after the first trimester. Individuals with neck problems should carefully position the head for comfort. Those who feel claustrophobic in prone positions may prefer supine relaxation.[7][4]

Common Mistakes:

Common errors include tensing the shoulders or holding muscular engagement. Practitioners may position the head uncomfortably, creating neck strain. Inadequate time in the pose reduces the relaxation benefit.[3][2]

Variations and Modifications:

A blanket can be placed under the chest for comfort. The arms can be positioned alongside the body instead of under the head. Individuals uncomfortable prone can practice other relaxation poses.[2]

Sources:

- Gheranda Samhita[8][1]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[3]
- NCCIH Yoga Benefits[4]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[7]

USTRASANA

Sanskrit Name: Ustrasana
English Name: Camel Pose
Meaning of Name: Ustra means camel[1][8]

Category: Prone Asana (Kneeling), Backbend
Difficulty Level: Intermediate to Advanced

Description:
Ustrasana is described in the Gheranda Samhita as opening the heart and enhancing flexibility. The pose is performed kneeling with a deep backbend. Light on Yoga includes this as an important heart-opening posture.[8][1][11][3][2]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin kneeling with knees hip-width apart and thighs perpendicular to the floor. Place the hands on the lower back with fingers pointing down. Engage the thighs and core while lifting the chest. Begin to arch back, keeping the hips over the knees. If flexibility allows, reach one hand at a time back to hold the heels. Allow the head to drop back if comfortable for the neck. Hold for 15 to 30 seconds with steady breathing, then carefully release.[11][3][2]

Benefits:
Ustrasana stretches the entire front body including hip flexors, abdomen, chest, and throat. The pose strengthens the back muscles and improves spinal flexibility. Research suggests backbending poses may improve posture. Traditional texts associate the pose with heart opening.[1][8][4][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary lengthening muscles include the rectus abdominis, hip flexors, pectoralis major, and anterior neck muscles. Working muscles include the erector spinae, gluteal muscles, hamstrings, and posterior shoulder muscles. The pose requires significant core engagement to protect the lower back.[2]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with lower back or neck injuries should avoid the full depth of the backbend. Those with high blood pressure or heart conditions should practice with caution. Pregnant women should avoid deep backbends after the first trimester. Individuals with knee problems should use padding under the knees.[10][7][4]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include compressing the lower back by bending primarily from the lumbar spine. Practitioners often fail to engage the gluteal muscles and thighs, creating instability. Dropping the head back without neck strength can strain the cervical spine.[3][2]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners should keep the hands on the lower back and maintain a gentle backbend. Blocks can be placed

outside the ankles to reduce the depth. Advanced practitioners may perform the full expression with hands on heels.[11][2]

Sources:

- Gheranda Samhita[8][1]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[11][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[2]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[10][4]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[7]

5. FORWARD BENDS

PASCHIMOTTANASANA

Sanskrit Name: Paschimottanasana
English Name: Seated Forward Bend
Meaning of Name: Paschima means west or back of the body, uttana means intense stretch[1][8]

Category: Forward Bend, Sitting
Difficulty Level: Beginner to Intermediate

Description:
Paschimottanasana is described in the Gheranda Samhita as encouraging introspection and deep stretching. Light on Yoga presents this as one of the most important seated forward bends. The Hatha Yoga Pradipika describes it among essential postures.[13][8][1][11][3]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin seated in Dandasana with legs extended forward. Inhale and lengthen the spine upward. Exhale and hinge forward from the hips, keeping the back straight as long as possible. Hold the feet, ankles, or shins depending on flexibility. Continue to lengthen the front torso with each inhale. Deepen the forward fold with each exhale. Hold for 1 to 3 minutes with steady breathing, then slowly rise.[11][3][2]

Benefits:
Paschimottanasana stretches the hamstrings, calves, and back muscles. The pose may reduce stress and

calm the mind. Research suggests forward bends may activate the parasympathetic nervous system. Traditional texts attribute digestive benefits and energy regulation to the pose.[8][1][4][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary lengthening muscles include the hamstrings, gastrocnemius, erector spinae, and gluteal muscles. Working muscles include the hip flexors and core muscles to maintain the forward fold. The parasympathetic nervous system may be activated during sustained holds.[4][2]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with lower back injuries should practice with bent knees or avoid deep forward bends. Those with hamstring injuries should practice gently without forcing. Individuals with sciatica should use caution and may need modifications.[4]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include rounding the back from the beginning rather than hinging from the hips. Practitioners often force the forward fold using arm strength instead of allowing gradual release. Bouncing or using momentum can cause hamstring injury.[4][3][2]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners should sit on a folded blanket and bend the knees as needed. A strap can be looped around the feet to extend reach. Those with tight hamstrings should prioritize spinal length over depth. Advanced practitioners may hold the outer edges of the feet and bring the forehead to the shins.[1][2][3]

Sources:

- Gheranda Samhita[4][5]
- Hatha Yoga Pradipika[6]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[2][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[7]

JANU SIRSASANA

Sanskrit Name: Janu Sirsasana
English Name: Head-to-Knee Pose
Meaning of Name: Janu means knee, sirsa means head[3]

Category: Forward Bend, Sitting
Difficulty Level: Beginner to Intermediate

Description:
Janu Sirsasana is presented in Light on Yoga as an asymmetrical forward bend combining elements of hip opening and hamstring stretching. The pose involves bending one knee while extending the other leg. The asana allows for deeper focus on one side at a time.[2][3][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin seated in Dandasana. Bend the right knee and place the sole of the right foot against the inner left thigh. Turn the torso slightly toward the extended left leg. Inhale and lengthen the spine. Exhale and fold forward over the extended leg, reaching for the foot, ankle, or shin. Keep the shoulders level and the extended leg active. Hold for 1 to 3 minutes with steady breathing, then repeat on the opposite side.[3][1][2]

Benefits:
Janu Sirsasana stretches the hamstrings, calves, and back muscles of the extended leg. The pose opens the hip of the bent leg. Research suggests forward bends may promote relaxation. Traditional understanding associates the pose with calming effects on the nervous system.[7][1][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary lengthening muscles include the hamstrings and gastrocnemius of the extended leg, hip external rotators of the bent leg, and erector spinae. Working muscles include the hip flexors and core stabilizers. The parasympathetic nervous system may be activated.[1][7]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with knee injuries should avoid placing the foot against the inner thigh or use support under the bent knee. Those with lower back injuries should practice with caution and maintain spinal length. Individuals with hamstring injuries should practice gently.[7]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include twisting the torso away from the extended leg rather than squaring the shoulders. Practitioners often round the back prematurely instead of maintaining length. Forcing the bent knee toward the floor can strain the knee joint.[2][1][7]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners should sit on a folded blanket and use a strap around the extended foot. Support can be placed under the bent knee. Advanced practitioners may bind the hands around the extended foot.[3][1]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[2][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[7]

UTTANASANA

Sanskrit Name: Uttanasana
English Name: Standing Forward Bend
Meaning of Name: Ut means intense, tan means to stretch or extend[3]

Category: Forward Bend, Standing
Difficulty Level: Beginner to Intermediate

Description:
Uttanasana is described in Light on Yoga as a fundamental standing forward bend. The pose involves folding forward from a standing position with emphasis on hip hinge. The asana is commonly used in sun salutation sequences.[1][2][3]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin standing in Tadasana. Inhale and extend the arms overhead. Exhale and hinge forward from the hips, maintaining spinal length initially. Allow the arms and head to hang toward the floor. Hands can rest on the shins, ankles, or floor. Engage the quadriceps to protect the hamstrings. Hold for 30 seconds to 1 minute with steady breathing, then slowly rise to standing.[2][3][1]

Benefits:
Uttanasana stretches the hamstrings, calves, and back muscles. The pose may reduce stress and mild anxiety. Research suggests forward bends with head below heart may have calming effects. Traditional understanding associates the pose with mental quieting.[7][1][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary lengthening muscles include the hamstrings, gastrocnemius, erector spinae, and gluteal muscles. The quadriceps work to stabilize the knees. The inverted position may influence blood pressure and nervous system activity.[8][1][7]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with lower back injuries should bend the knees and maintain spinal length. Those with high

blood pressure should practice with caution and rise slowly. Individuals with glaucoma or detached retina should avoid head-below-heart positions. Pregnant women should practice with feet wide apart.[9][8][7]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include rounding the back from the hips rather than hinging with a long spine. Practitioners often lock the knees, which creates hamstring strain. Rising too quickly can cause dizziness.[8][1][2]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners should bend the knees generously and place hands on blocks. Those with tight hamstrings should prioritize hip hinge over depth. Advanced practitioners may clasp opposite elbows overhead or bind the hands behind the back.[3][1][2]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[2][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[8][7]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[9]

PRASARITA PADOTTANASANA

Sanskrit Name: Prasarita Padottanasana
English Name: Wide-Legged Forward Bend
Meaning of Name: Prasarita means spread out, pada means foot, uttana means intense stretch[3]

Category: Forward Bend, Standing
Difficulty Level: Beginner to Intermediate

Description:
Prasarita Padottanasana is presented in Light on Yoga as a standing forward bend with a wide stance. The pose combines inner leg stretching with forward folding. Multiple arm variations exist in the classical teaching.[1][2][3]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin standing with feet 3 to 4 feet apart and parallel. Place hands on hips and lengthen the spine. Inhale and lift the chest. Exhale and hinge forward from the hips, maintaining spinal length. Place hands on the

floor between or in line with the feet. Continue to lengthen the spine with each inhale and deepen the fold with each exhale. Hold for 30 seconds to 1 minute, then rise slowly.[2][3][1]

Benefits:

Prasarita Padottanasana stretches the hamstrings, inner thighs, and back muscles. The pose strengthens the legs and may improve balance. Research suggests forward bends may promote relaxation. The inverted position may have calming effects.[7][1]

Muscles and Systems Involved:

Primary lengthening muscles include the hamstrings, adductors, gastrocnemius, and erector spinae. Working muscles include the quadriceps and core stabilizers. The inverted head position influences the nervous system.[7][1]

Contraindications and Precautions:

Individuals with lower back injuries should practice with hands on blocks and reduced forward fold. Those with high blood pressure should practice with caution. Individuals with hamstring injuries should reduce the depth.[8][7]

Common Mistakes:

Common errors include allowing the feet to turn outward rather than remaining parallel. Practitioners often round the back instead of hinging from the hips. Locking the knees creates unnecessary hamstring strain.[1][2]

Variations and Modifications:

Beginners should place hands on blocks and bend the knees as needed. Various arm positions can be explored including hands on hips or clasped behind the back. Advanced practitioners may place the crown of the head on the floor.[3][1]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[2][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[8][7]

BALASANA

Sanskrit Name: Balasana
English Name: Child's Pose
Meaning of Name: Bala means child[1]

Category: Forward Bend, Kneeling
Difficulty Level: Beginner

Description:
Balasana is taught in modern yoga as a resting and restorative forward fold. The pose involves kneeling with the torso folded over the thighs. The asana is commonly used as a rest pose between more active postures.[2][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin kneeling with knees together or hip-width apart. Sit back on the heels. Exhale and fold the torso forward, bringing the forehead to the floor. Arms can extend forward with palms down or rest alongside the body with palms up. Relax the shoulders and allow the back to round naturally. Breathe naturally and hold for 1 to 5 minutes.[2][1]

Benefits:
Balasana gently stretches the back, hips, and ankles. The pose promotes deep relaxation and stress reduction. Research suggests restorative poses may activate the parasympathetic nervous system. The folded position may provide a sense of security and calm.[7][1]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary lengthening muscles include the erector spinae, latissimus dorsi, and gluteal muscles. Minimal muscular effort is required. The parasympathetic nervous system is activated.[7][1]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Pregnant women should practice with knees wide apart to accommodate the abdomen. Individuals with knee injuries should place padding under the knees or avoid the pose. Those with ankle injuries should use support under the ankles.[9][7]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include forcing the hips to the heels when flexibility is limited. Practitioners often tense the shoulders rather than allowing complete relaxation. Inadequate time in the pose reduces the restorative benefit.[1][2]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners can place a folded blanket between the buttocks and heels. A bolster can be placed under the torso for support. Those with knee discomfort can reduce the depth or try a different resting pose.[1]

Sources:

- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[2]
- NCCIH Yoga Benefits[7]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[9]

6. BACKBENDS

URDHVA MUKHA SVANASANA

Sanskrit Name: Urdhva Mukha Svanasana
English Name: Upward-Facing Dog Pose
Meaning of Name: Urdhva mukha means face upward, svana means dog[3]

Category: Backbend, Prone
Difficulty Level: Intermediate

Description:
Urdhva Mukha Svanasana is described in Light on Yoga as an active backbend commonly included in sun salutation sequences. The pose involves lifting the entire body off the floor except the hands and tops of the feet. The asana differs from Bhujangasana in its more active, strengthening approach.[3][2][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin lying prone with hands beside the ribs and elbows bent. Press firmly through the hands and tops of the feet. Straighten the arms while lifting the thighs and torso off the floor. Roll the shoulders back and lift the chest forward and up. Keep the legs active and the thighs off the floor. Draw the shoulder blades down the back. Hold for 15 to 30 seconds with steady breathing, then release.[2][1]

Benefits:
Urdhva Mukha Svanasana strengthens the arms, wrists, and spinal extensors. The pose stretches the

chest, abdomen, and hip flexors. Research suggests backbending poses may improve spinal flexibility. Traditional understanding associates the pose with energizing effects.[7][2][1]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary working muscles include the triceps, erector spinae, gluteal muscles, quadriceps, and posterior shoulder muscles. Lengthening muscles include the rectus abdominis, hip flexors, and pectoralis major. The pose requires significant upper body and core strength.[1]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with lower back injuries should practice with caution or substitute Bhujangasana. Those with wrist injuries should modify or avoid the pose. Pregnant women should avoid prone backbends after the first trimester. Individuals with carpal tunnel syndrome should practice with caution.[9][7]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include allowing the shoulders to hunch toward the ears. Practitioners often sag in the lower back rather than engaging the legs and core. Insufficient arm strength leads to compensation patterns.[2][1]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners should practice Bhujangasana instead until sufficient strength develops. The thighs can remain on the floor as a modification. Advanced practitioners may increase the duration.[3][1]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[3][2]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[7]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[9]

CHAKRASANA

Sanskrit Name: Chakrasana (Urdhva Dhanurasana)
English Name: Wheel Pose or Upward Bow Pose
Meaning of Name: Chakra means wheel, urdhva means upward, dhanu means bow[4][3]

Category: Backbend, Supine
Difficulty Level: Advanced

Description:

Chakrasana is described in the Gheranda Samhita as an advanced backbend. Light on Yoga presents Urdhva Dhanurasana as a full wheel pose requiring significant strength and flexibility. The pose involves a complete arch of the body supported on hands and feet.[5][4][3][2][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:

Lie on the back with knees bent and feet hip-width apart, heels close to the buttocks. Bend the elbows and place the palms beside the ears with fingers pointing toward the shoulders. Press firmly through the feet and hands. Lift the hips and place the crown of the head on the floor briefly. Straighten the arms and lift the head off the floor, arching the entire body. Keep the feet parallel and the knees tracking forward. Hold for 5 to 30 seconds with steady breathing, then carefully lower.[3][2][1]

Benefits:

Chakrasana strengthens the arms, wrists, legs, spine, and shoulders. The pose stretches the entire front body. Research suggests backbends may improve spinal mobility. Traditional texts describe the pose as energizing and awakening.[5][4][7][1]

Muscles and Systems Involved:

Primary working muscles include the triceps, erector spinae, gluteus maximus, quadriceps, hamstrings, and shoulder extensors. Lengthening muscles include the entire anterior chain: hip flexors, rectus abdominis, pectoralis major, and anterior deltoids. The pose significantly engages the cardiovascular system.[1]

Contraindications and Precautions:

Individuals with lower back, wrist, or shoulder injuries should avoid this advanced backbend. Those with high blood pressure or heart conditions should not practice the pose. Pregnant women should avoid deep backbends. Individuals with carpal tunnel syndrome or osteoporosis should avoid the pose.[8][9][7]

Common Mistakes:

Common errors include allowing the feet to turn outward or the knees to splay. Practitioners often lack adequate shoulder flexibility, limiting the full expression. Insufficient warm-up increases injury risk.[7][2][1]

Variations and Modifications:

Beginners should practice preparatory backbends like Bridge Pose for months before attempting Wheel Pose. Blocks can be placed against a wall for the hands. Advanced practitioners may lift one leg or perform the pose from standing.[3][1]

Sources:

- Gheranda Samhita[4][5]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[2][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[8][7]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[9]

MATSYASANA

Sanskrit Name: Matsyasana
English Name: Fish Pose
Meaning of Name: Matsya means fish[5][4]

Category: Backbend, Supine
Difficulty Level: Beginner to Intermediate

Description:
Matsyasana is described in the Gheranda Samhita as one of the classical postures. Light on Yoga presents this as a counterpose to shoulder stand that opens the throat and chest. The pose involves arching the back while lying supine.[4][5][3][2][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Lie on the back with legs extended and arms alongside the body. Press the forearms and elbows into the floor. Lift the chest and arch the upper back. Gently lower the crown of the head toward or onto the floor. The majority of weight remains on the elbows and forearms, not the head. Hold for 15 to 30 seconds with steady breathing, then carefully release.[3][2][1]

Benefits:
Matsyasana stretches the throat, chest, and hip flexors. The pose may improve spinal flexibility. Traditional texts describe the pose as beneficial for respiratory function. Research on specific benefits is limited.[10][5][4][7][1]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary working muscles include the erector spinae, posterior neck muscles, and triceps. Lengthening muscles include the pectoralis major, anterior neck muscles, and hip flexors. The pose opens the throat region.[1]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with neck injuries should avoid this pose or practice with minimal head contact. Those with lower back injuries should practice with caution. Individuals with high blood pressure should avoid the full expression.[8][7]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include placing too much weight on the head rather than the elbows. Practitioners often arch primarily from the lower back instead of the upper back. Dropping the head back without control can strain the neck.[7][2][1]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners can place a folded blanket under the upper back for support. The legs can be in Padmasana for the classical variation if hip flexibility allows. A block can support the upper back in a restorative version.[4][3][1]

Sources:

- Gheranda Samhita[5][4]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[2][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[8][7]

ANJANEYASANA

Sanskrit Name: Anjaneyasana
English Name: Low Lunge or Crescent Lunge
Meaning of Name: Named after Anjaneya (Hanuman), son of Anjani[1]

Category: Backbend, Lunge
Difficulty Level: Beginner to Intermediate

Description:
Anjaneyasana is taught in modern yoga as a hip-opening backbend in a lunge position. The pose combines hip flexor stretching with spinal extension. The asana is commonly used in transitional sequences.[2][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin in a kneeling position. Step the right foot forward between the hands with the knee over the ankle.

Lower the left knee to the floor and slide it back. Press the hips forward while keeping the right knee stable. Inhale and raise the arms overhead. Arch the upper back gently and lift the chest. Hold for 30 seconds to 1 minute with steady breathing, then repeat on the opposite side.[2][1]

Benefits:

Anjaneyasana stretches the hip flexors, quadriceps, and chest. The pose strengthens the legs and improves balance. Research suggests hip-opening poses may improve flexibility. The backbending component opens the chest and shoulders.[7][1]

Muscles and Systems Involved:

Primary lengthening muscles include the hip flexors and quadriceps of the back leg, pectoralis major, and anterior deltoids. Working muscles include the gluteus maximus and quadriceps of the front leg, erector spinae, and core stabilizers. The cardiovascular system is moderately engaged.[1]

Contraindications and Precautions:

Individuals with knee injuries should pad the back knee well or avoid kneeling. Those with hip injuries should practice with reduced depth. Individuals with high blood pressure should keep arms at chest level.[8][7]

Common Mistakes:

Common errors include allowing the front knee to extend beyond the ankle. Practitioners often arch excessively from the lower back rather than the upper back. Inadequate padding under the back knee creates discomfort.[2][1]

Variations and Modifications:

Beginners should place padding under the back knee and keep hands on the front thigh. The back toes can be tucked under for a more active variation. Advanced practitioners may add a deeper backbend or arm variations.[3][1]

Sources:

- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[3][2]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[8][7]

7. TWISTS

ARDHA MATSYENDRASANA

Sanskrit Name: Ardha Matsyendrasana
English Name: Half Lord of the Fishes Pose
Meaning of Name: Ardha means half, Matsyendra was a legendary yogi[5][4]

Category: Twist, Sitting
Difficulty Level: Intermediate

Description:
Ardha Matsyendrasana is described in the Gheranda Samhita as one of the classical seated twists. The pose involves crossing one leg over the other while twisting the spine. Traditional texts attribute numerous health benefits to spinal twisting.[4][5][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin seated with legs extended forward. Bend the right knee and place the right foot flat on the floor outside the left knee. Bend the left knee and place the left foot beside the right hip. Lengthen the spine and twist to the right. Place the right hand on the floor behind the sacrum. Bring the left elbow to the outside of the right knee or wrap the left arm around the right shin. Hold for 30 seconds to 1 minute with steady breathing, then repeat on the opposite side.[3][2][1]

Benefits:
Ardha Matsyendrasana increases spinal mobility and flexibility. The pose stretches the shoulders, hips, and outer thighs. Traditional texts describe digestive and detoxification benefits, though scientific evidence is limited. Research suggests twisting poses may improve spinal rotation.[5][4][7][1]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary working and lengthening muscles include the obliques, erector spinae, hip external rotators, and pectoralis major. The pose engages multiple layers of core musculature. Traditional understanding suggests the pose influences organ function.[4][5][1]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with spinal injuries should practice with caution or avoid deep twists. Pregnant women should practice open twists only, avoiding compression of the abdomen. Those with hip or knee injuries should modify the leg position.[9][7]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include rounding the back rather than maintaining spinal length. Practitioners often twist

from the neck instead of the thoracic spine. Forcing the twist without adequate spinal mobility can cause strain.[7][2][1]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners can practice with the bottom leg extended. A blanket under the hips elevates and supports spinal alignment. The arm position can be simplified.[2][1]

Sources:

- Gheranda Samhita[5][4]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[3][2]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[7]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[9]

BHARADVAJASANA

Sanskrit Name: Bharadvajasana
English Name: Bharadvaja's Twist
Meaning of Name: Named after sage Bharadvaja[3]

Category: Twist, Sitting
Difficulty Level: Beginner to Intermediate

Description:
Bharadvajasana is presented in Light on Yoga as a gentler seated twist suitable for most practitioners. The pose involves a simple seated position with spinal rotation. The asana is considered safer for those with spinal concerns than deeper twists.[2][3][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin seated with legs extended forward. Bend both knees and swing the legs to the left, placing both feet beside the left hip. Sit evenly on both sitting bones. Lengthen the spine and twist to the right. Place the right hand on the floor behind the sacrum. Bring the left hand to the right outer thigh or knee. Hold for 30 seconds to 1 minute with steady breathing, then repeat on the opposite side.[3][2][1]

Benefits:
Bharadvajasana gently improves spinal mobility. The pose stretches the shoulders and outer hips. Research suggests gentle twisting may benefit spinal health. The pose is commonly recommended for mild back discomfort.[7][2][1]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary muscles involved include the obliques, erector spinae, and rotator muscles of the spine. The pose engages the shoulder girdle muscles. The twisting action provides gentle spinal mobilization.[1]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with spinal disc injuries should practice with caution. Pregnant women should practice open twists only. Those with knee problems should modify the leg position.[9][7]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include rounding the spine instead of maintaining length. Practitioners often twist primarily from the neck. Uneven weight distribution on the sitting bones reduces effectiveness.[2][1]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners can sit on a folded blanket for elevation. The legs can be in a simpler cross-legged position. Various arm positions can be explored.[3][1]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[2][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[7]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[9]

PARIVRTTA TRIKONASANA

Sanskrit Name: Parivrtta Trikonasana
English Name: Revolved Triangle Pose
Meaning of Name: Parivrtta means revolved or rotated, trikona means triangle[3]

Category: Twist, Standing
Difficulty Level: Intermediate to Advanced

Description:

Parivrtta Trikonasana is described in Light on Yoga as a challenging standing twist that combines balance with spinal rotation. The pose requires hamstring flexibility, balance, and core strength. The asana creates a triangle shape while twisting the torso.[2][3][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:

Begin standing with feet 3 to 4 feet apart. Turn the right foot out 90 degrees and the left foot in slightly. Square the hips toward the front. Exhale and fold forward, placing the left hand on the floor beside the right foot or on a block. Twist the torso to the right and extend the right arm upward. Keep both legs straight and engaged. Hold for 30 seconds to 1 minute with steady breathing, then repeat on the opposite side.[3][2][1]

Benefits:

Parivrtta Trikonasana strengthens the legs and improves balance. The pose increases spinal mobility and stretches the hamstrings. Research suggests balancing poses improve proprioception. Traditional understanding attributes detoxification benefits, though scientific evidence is lacking.[10][7][1]

Muscles and Systems Involved:

Primary working muscles include the quadriceps, core stabilizers, obliques, and spinal rotators. Lengthening muscles include the hamstrings, hip muscles, and lateral torso. The pose significantly challenges the proprioceptive system.[7][1]

Contraindications and Precautions:

Individuals with lower back injuries should practice with caution or avoid the pose. Those with balance difficulties should practice near a wall. Individuals with high blood pressure should avoid the full depth.[11][8][7]

Common Mistakes:

Common errors include rounding the back rather than maintaining spinal length. Practitioners often fail to square the hips before twisting. Forcing the twist without adequate preparation creates strain.[7][2][1]

Variations and Modifications:

Beginners should use a block under the bottom hand and reduce the twist. The back heel can lift for better hip squaring. Advanced practitioners may bind the arms.[2][3][1]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[3][2]

- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[11][8][7]

PARIVRTTA PARSVAKONASANA

Sanskrit Name: Parivrtta Parsvakonasana
English Name: Revolved Side Angle Pose
Meaning of Name: Parivrtta means revolved, parsva means side, kona means angle[3]

Category: Twist, Standing
Difficulty Level: Intermediate to Advanced

Description:
Parivrtta Parsvakonasana is presented in Light on Yoga as an advanced standing twist requiring strength, flexibility, and balance. The pose combines a lunge position with deep spinal rotation. The asana challenges the entire body simultaneously.[2][3][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin in a lunge with the right foot forward and the knee bent to 90 degrees. Keep the back leg straight or lower the back knee for support. Bring the hands to prayer position at the heart center. Twist to the right and hook the left elbow outside the right knee. Press the hands together to deepen the twist. Keep the spine long and the chest rotating toward the ceiling. Hold for 30 seconds to 1 minute with steady breathing, then repeat on the opposite side.[2][3][1]

Benefits:
Parivrtta Parsvakonasana strengthens the legs, core, and improves balance. The pose increases spinal mobility and opens the chest. Research suggests complex poses may improve body awareness. The twisting action mobilizes the thoracic spine.[7][1]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary working muscles include the quadriceps, gluteal muscles, core stabilizers, obliques, and spinal rotators. The pose engages the entire kinetic chain. The proprioceptive and vestibular systems are highly challenged.[7][1]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with knee injuries should practice with the back knee down and reduced depth. Those with

lower back or spinal injuries should avoid deep twisting. Individuals with balance difficulties should practice near support.[11][7]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include allowing the front knee to collapse inward. Practitioners often round the back rather than maintaining spinal extension. Forcing the twist without adequate core strength creates compensation.[1][2]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners should practice with the back knee down and hands in prayer at the chest. A block under the bottom hand provides support. Advanced practitioners may bind the arms beneath the front thigh.[3][1]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[2][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[11][7]

SUPTA MATSYENDRASANA

Sanskrit Name: Supta Matsyendrasana
English Name: Supine Spinal Twist
Meaning of Name: Supta means reclined, Matsyendra was a legendary yogi[1]

Category: Twist, Supine
Difficulty Level: Beginner

Description:
Supta Matsyendrasana is taught in modern yoga as a gentle supine twist suitable for most practitioners. The pose allows gravity to assist the twisting action while the back remains supported. The asana is commonly used in restorative and therapeutic sequences.[2][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Lie on the back with arms extended to the sides at shoulder height. Bend the right knee and bring it toward the chest. Guide the right knee across the body to the left with the left hand. Turn the head to the right. Keep the right shoulder grounded or allow it to lift naturally. Hold for 1 to 3 minutes with natural breathing, then repeat on the opposite side.[2][1]

Benefits:

Supta Matsyendrasana gently mobilizes the spine and stretches the outer hips. The pose promotes relaxation and may reduce lower back tension. Research suggests gentle movements may benefit spinal health. The supine position minimizes risk.[7][1]

Muscles and Systems Involved:

Primary lengthening muscles include the obliques, erector spinae, gluteal muscles, and hip external rotators. The pose involves passive stretching with minimal effort. The parasympathetic nervous system may be activated.[7][1]

Contraindications and Precautions:

Pregnant women should practice with knees separated to avoid abdominal compression. Individuals with spinal injuries should practice with reduced range of motion. Those with hip replacements should avoid crossed-body positions.[9][7]

Common Mistakes:

Common errors include forcing the knee to the floor when flexibility is limited. Practitioners often lift the opposite shoulder excessively. Rushing through the pose reduces the therapeutic benefit.[1][2]

Variations and Modifications:

Beginners can place a bolster under the bent knee for support. Both knees can be bent together for a gentler version. The bottom leg can remain bent or extended.[1]

Sources:

- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[2]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[7]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[9]

8. BALANCING ASANAS

BAKASANA

Sanskrit Name: Bakasana
English Name: Crow Pose or Crane Pose
Meaning of Name: Baka means crow or crane[4][5]

Category: Balancing Asana, Arm Balance
Difficulty Level: Intermediate

Description:
Bakasana is described in the Gheranda Samhita as developing strength and concentration. The pose involves balancing the body weight on the hands with knees resting on the upper arms. Light on Yoga presents this as a foundational arm balance.[5][4][3][2][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin in a squat with feet hip-width apart. Place the hands on the floor shoulder-width apart with fingers spread wide. Bend the elbows slightly and place the knees on the backs of the upper arms. Shift weight forward onto the hands, engaging the core muscles. Lift one foot, then the other, bringing the heels toward the buttocks. Balance on the hands with arms supporting the body weight. Hold for 10 to 30 seconds with steady breathing, then carefully release.[3][2][1]

Benefits:
Bakasana strengthens the arms, wrists, and core muscles. The pose improves balance, coordination, and concentration. Research suggests arm balances may build upper body strength. Traditional texts attribute mental focus benefits to balancing poses.[4][5][7][1]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary working muscles include the triceps, serratus anterior, core stabilizers, hip flexors, and shoulder girdle muscles. The pose requires significant wrist stability. The proprioceptive system and core control are essential.[7][1]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with wrist or shoulder injuries should avoid arm balances. Those with carpal tunnel syndrome should not practice the pose. Pregnant women should avoid inversions and arm balances after the first trimester.[9][7]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include keeping the arms straight rather than slightly bent. Practitioners often fail to engage the core, relying solely on arm strength. Placing the knees too low on the arms reduces stability.[2][1]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners should practice lifting one foot at a time. Blocks can be placed under the feet for confidence building. Advanced practitioners may straighten the arms fully or transition to other poses.[3][1]

Sources:

- Gheranda Samhita[5][4]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[3][2]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[7]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[9]

NATARAJASANA

Sanskrit Name: Natarajasana
English Name: Dancer's Pose or Lord of the Dance Pose
Meaning of Name: Nata means dancer, raja means king or lord[3]

Category: Balancing Asana, Backbend
Difficulty Level: Intermediate to Advanced

Description:
Natarajasana is presented in Light on Yoga as a standing balance that combines backbending with single-leg support. The pose creates a graceful arc of the body while requiring significant balance and flexibility. The asana represents the cosmic dance of Lord Shiva.[3][2][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin standing in Tadasana. Shift weight onto the left foot. Bend the right knee and reach back with the right hand to hold the right ankle or foot. Extend the left arm forward and up. Begin to kick the right foot into the right hand while hinging forward slightly. The lifted leg rises as the chest lowers, creating a counterbalance. Hold for 15 to 30 seconds with steady breathing, then repeat on the opposite side.[2][3][1]

Benefits:
Natarajasana strengthens the standing leg, ankles, and core muscles. The pose stretches the shoulders, chest, thighs, and hip flexors. Research suggests balancing poses improve proprioception and reduce fall risk. The combination of balance and backbending challenges body awareness.[12][7][1]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary working muscles include the quadriceps and gluteal muscles of the standing leg, ankle stabilizers, core muscles, and shoulder stabilizers. Lengthening muscles include the hip flexors and quadriceps of the lifted leg, pectoralis major, and anterior deltoids. The vestibular and proprioceptive systems are highly engaged.[7][1]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with ankle or knee injuries should practice near support or avoid the pose. Those with lower back problems should maintain a gentler backbend. Individuals with balance disorders should practice near a wall.[11][7]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include allowing the standing knee to hyperextend or lock. Practitioners often fail to engage the core, creating lower back compression. Gripping the toes instead of the ankle or foot reduces effectiveness.[3][2][1]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners should practice near a wall for support and maintain a gentle lift of the back leg. A strap can be looped around the back foot. Advanced practitioners may use both hands to hold the back foot and deepen the backbend.[3][1]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[2][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- NCCIH Yoga for Balance[12][11][7]

ARDHA CHANDRASANA

Sanskrit Name: Ardha Chandrasana
English Name: Half Moon Pose
Meaning of Name: Ardha means half, chandra means moon[3]

Category: Balancing Asana, Standing
Difficulty Level: Intermediate

Description:

Ardha Chandrasana is described in Light on Yoga as a standing balance that combines leg strengthening with lateral body opening. The pose creates a half-moon arc shape with the body. The asana requires significant balance, flexibility, and core strength.[2][1][3]

Step-by-Step Practice:

Begin in Utthita Trikonasana on the right side. Bend the right knee and place the right hand on the floor or a block 12 inches in front of the right foot. Shift weight onto the right foot and hand. Straighten the right leg while lifting the left leg parallel to the floor. Stack the hips and rotate the chest toward the ceiling. Extend the left arm upward. Gaze up at the left thumb or forward for better balance. Hold for 30 seconds to 1 minute with steady breathing, then repeat on the opposite side.[1][2][3]

Benefits:

Ardha Chandrasana strengthens the legs, ankles, and core muscles. The pose improves balance and coordination. Research suggests standing balances may reduce fall risk. The lateral opening stretches the hamstrings and outer hips.[12][7][1]

Muscles and Systems Involved:

Primary working muscles include the quadriceps and gluteal muscles of the standing leg, ankle stabilizers, and core stabilizers. Lengthening muscles include the hamstrings of the lifted leg and lateral torso muscles. The proprioceptive system is significantly challenged.[7][1]

Contraindications and Precautions:

Individuals with balance difficulties should practice near a wall. Those with neck problems should keep the gaze forward rather than upward. Individuals with low blood pressure should rise slowly into the pose.[11][8][7]

Common Mistakes:

Common errors include allowing the hips to collapse forward rather than stacking. Practitioners often lock the standing knee, reducing stability. Placing too much weight on the bottom hand creates shoulder strain.[2][1]

Variations and Modifications:

Beginners should practice with the back against a wall and use a block under the bottom hand. The top hand can rest on the hip instead of extending upward. Advanced practitioners may attempt the pose without hand support.[3][1][2]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[2][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- NCCIH Yoga for Balance[12][11][8][7]

VIRABHADRASANA III

Sanskrit Name: Virabhadrasana III
English Name: Warrior Pose III
Meaning of Name: Third variation of the warrior pose series, named after warrior Virabhadra[3]

Category: Balancing Asana, Standing
Difficulty Level: Intermediate to Advanced

Description:
Virabhadrasana III is presented in Light on Yoga as a challenging standing balance requiring strength, flexibility, and concentration. The pose creates a horizontal line with the body balanced on one leg. The asana integrates balance with hip extension and core stability.[1][2][3]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin in Virabhadrasana I on the right side. Shift weight onto the right foot. Hinge forward from the hips as the left leg lifts behind. Extend the arms forward alongside the ears or extend them back alongside the body. Create a straight line from fingertips to back heel, parallel to the floor. Keep the hips level and the standing leg strong. Hold for 15 to 30 seconds with steady breathing, then repeat on the opposite side.[2][3][1]

Benefits:
Virabhadrasana III strengthens the legs, ankles, core, and shoulders. The pose improves balance, coordination, and full-body integration. Research suggests balancing poses enhance proprioception. The horizontal alignment challenges postural control.[12][7][1]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary working muscles include the quadriceps and gluteal muscles of the standing leg, hamstrings and gluteus maximus of the lifted leg, core stabilizers, and shoulder stabilizers. The entire posterior chain is engaged. The vestibular and proprioceptive systems work intensively.[7][1]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with balance difficulties should practice near a wall or chair. Those with high blood pressure should practice with caution due to the forward-folded position. Individuals with lower back problems should avoid overarching.[11][8][7]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include allowing the hips to rotate open rather than keeping them level. Practitioners often arch the lower back excessively. Locking the standing knee reduces stability.[1][2]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners should practice with hands on a wall or chair for support. The back leg can be lower than hip height. Advanced practitioners may add arm variations or practice with eyes closed.[3][2][1]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[2][3]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- NCCIH Yoga for Balance[12][11][8][7]

9. INVERSIONS

ADHO MUKHA SVANASANA

Sanskrit Name: Adho Mukha Svanasana
English Name: Downward-Facing Dog Pose
Meaning of Name: Adho mukha means face downward, svana means dog[3]

Category: Inversion, Standing
Difficulty Level: Beginner to Intermediate

Description:
Adho Mukha Svanasana is described in Light on Yoga as one of the most fundamental yoga poses. The pose creates an inverted V-shape with the body. The asana is commonly used as a transitional pose and resting position in flow sequences.[2][3][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin on hands and knees with hands shoulder-width apart and knees hip-width apart. Spread the fingers

wide and press firmly through the hands. Tuck the toes and lift the hips up and back. Straighten the legs as much as flexibility allows while maintaining length in the spine. Press the heels toward the floor. Draw the shoulder blades down the back and externally rotate the upper arms. Hold for 1 to 3 minutes with steady breathing.[3][1][2]

Benefits:

Adho Mukha Svanasana stretches the hamstrings, calves, shoulders, and hands. The pose strengthens the arms, shoulders, and legs. Research suggests inversions may have calming effects. The pose can serve as both an active strengthening pose and a resting position.[7][1][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:

Primary lengthening muscles include the hamstrings, gastrocnemius, shoulder external rotators, and latissimus dorsi. Working muscles include the quadriceps, triceps, serratus anterior, and core stabilizers. The mild inversion may influence cardiovascular function.[7][1]

Contraindications and Precautions:

Individuals with wrist or shoulder injuries should modify or avoid the pose. Those with high blood pressure should practice with caution. Individuals with carpal tunnel syndrome should use wedges under the hands. Pregnant women in later stages should practice with modifications.[8][9][7]

Common Mistakes:

Common errors include allowing the shoulders to collapse toward the ears. Practitioners often round the upper back rather than maintaining spinal length. Locking the elbows creates joint stress.[1][2]

Variations and Modifications:

Beginners should keep the knees bent to maintain spinal length. The heels do not need to touch the floor. Advanced practitioners may lift one leg at a time.[2][3][1]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[3][2]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[8][7]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[9]

SIRSASANA

Sanskrit Name: Sirsasana
English Name: Headstand
Meaning of Name: Sirsa means head[4][5]

Category: Inversion
Difficulty Level: Advanced

Description:
Sirsasana is described in the Hatha Yoga Pradipika as the king of asanas. Light on Yoga presents detailed instructions for this foundational inversion. The pose involves balancing the body weight on the forearms and head. Traditional texts attribute numerous benefits to headstand practice.[13][6][4][2][3][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin kneeling on the floor. Interlace the fingers and place the forearms on the floor with elbows shoulder-width apart. Place the crown of the head on the floor with the back of the head cradled in the interlaced hands. Lift the hips and walk the feet toward the head. Engage the core and lift both legs up, straightening them toward the ceiling. Balance with most weight on the forearms, not the head. Hold for 30 seconds to 5 minutes depending on experience, then carefully lower.[2][3][1]

Benefits:
Traditional texts describe Sirsasana as improving circulation and cognitive function. The pose strengthens the shoulders, arms, and core muscles. Research on inversions suggests potential effects on cardiovascular and nervous system function, though evidence is limited. The NCCIH notes that inversions should be avoided by many populations.[6][11][4][7][1]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary working muscles include the shoulder stabilizers, triceps, serratus anterior, and entire core musculature. The pose requires significant upper body strength and core control. The inverted position influences blood flow and intraocular pressure.[7][1]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with neck, back, or shoulder injuries should avoid headstand. Those with high blood pressure, heart disease, or glaucoma should not practice inversions. The NCCIH specifically recommends avoiding headstand for most practitioners. Pregnant women should avoid inversions. Individuals with osteoporosis or detached retina must avoid this pose.[11][8][9][7]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include placing too much weight on the head rather than the forearms. Practitioners often

attempt the pose without adequate shoulder strength and core stability. Insufficient preparation and supervision increases injury risk significantly.[11][7][1][2]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners should not attempt this pose without extensive preparation and qualified instruction. Forearm stand or shoulderstand may be safer alternatives. Wall support can be used during learning stages.[11][1][2]

Sources:

- Hatha Yoga Pradipika[13][6]
- Gheranda Samhita[4]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[3][2]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- NCCIH Yoga Safety[11][8][7]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[9]

SARVANGASANA

Sanskrit Name: Sarvangasana
English Name: Shoulderstand
Meaning of Name: Sarva means all or whole, anga means limb[5][4]

Category: Inversion
Difficulty Level: Intermediate to Advanced

Description:
Sarvangasana is described in classical texts and Light on Yoga as the queen of asanas. The pose involves inverting the body with support on the shoulders and upper arms. Traditional texts attribute extensive health benefits to regular practice.[5][4][2][3][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Lie on the back with arms alongside the body. Lift the legs overhead and support the back with the hands. Walk the hands down the back toward the shoulder blades. Extend the legs vertically toward the ceiling, creating a straight line from shoulders to feet. The weight rests on the shoulders and upper arms, never on the neck. Hold for 1 to 5 minutes depending on experience, then slowly lower.[2][3][1]

Benefits:

Traditional texts describe Sarvangasana as beneficial for thyroid function and circulation. The pose strengthens the upper back and shoulders. Research on inversions is limited but suggests potential nervous system effects. Light on Yoga attributes numerous therapeutic benefits to the pose.[4][5][7][1][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:

Primary working muscles include the erector spinae, trapezius, shoulder stabilizers, and core muscles. The cervical spine is in flexion. The inverted position influences cardiovascular and endocrine function according to traditional understanding.[5][4][1]

Contraindications and Precautions:

Individuals with neck injuries or cervical spine problems should avoid shoulderstand. Those with high blood pressure, heart conditions, or glaucoma should not practice inversions. The NCCIH recommends avoiding inversions for most people. Pregnant women should avoid the pose. Individuals with detached retina or osteoporosis must avoid this inversion.[11][8][9][7]

Common Mistakes:

Common errors include placing weight on the neck rather than the shoulders. Practitioners often lack adequate upper body strength for safe practice. Inadequate warm-up and preparation increases injury risk.[11][7][1][2]

Variations and Modifications:

Beginners should practice with folded blankets under the shoulders to protect the neck. Supported variations using a wall or chair are safer for learning. The pose requires qualified instruction.[11][1][2]

Sources:

- Gheranda Samhita[4][5]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[3][2]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- NCCIH Yoga Safety[8][11][7]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[9]

VIPARITA KARANI

Sanskrit Name: Viparita Karani
English Name: Legs-Up-the-Wall Pose
Meaning of Name: Viparita means inverted or reversed, karani means action[5][4]

Category: Inversion, Restorative
Difficulty Level: Beginner

Description:
Viparita Karani is described in the Hatha Yoga Pradipika as an important practice. Modern yoga teaching presents this as a gentle, accessible inversion. The pose involves resting the legs vertically against a wall while lying on the back.[6][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Sit sideways next to a wall. Swing the legs up the wall as the back lowers to the floor. Adjust the hips to be a comfortable distance from the wall, typically 3 to 6 inches. Rest the arms alongside the body with palms facing up. Allow the legs to relax completely against the wall. Close the eyes and breathe naturally for 5 to 15 minutes.[2][1]

Benefits:
Viparita Karani may reduce leg swelling and promote relaxation. The gentle inversion can help reduce stress. Research suggests restorative poses activate the parasympathetic nervous system. The pose is commonly used for recovery and stress management.[7][1][2]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
All muscles are passively relaxed. The mild inversion assists venous return from the legs. The parasympathetic nervous system is activated.[7][1]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with glaucoma or detached retina should avoid even mild inversions. Those in the second half of pregnancy should elevate the upper body or avoid the pose. Individuals with uncontrolled high blood pressure should practice with caution.[8][9][7]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include placing the hips too close or too far from the wall. Practitioners often tense the legs rather than allowing complete relaxation. Inadequate time in the pose reduces the restorative benefit.[1][2]

Variations and Modifications:
A folded blanket or bolster can be placed under the hips for elevation. The legs can be in a V-shape against the wall. Distance from the wall can be adjusted for comfort.[1]

Sources:

- Hatha Yoga Pradipika[6]
- Gheranda Samhita[4][5]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[2]
- NCCIH Yoga Benefits[8][7]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[9]

10. RELAXATION AND RESTORATIVE ASANAS

SUPTA VIRASANA

Sanskrit Name: Supta Virasana
English Name: Reclined Hero Pose
Meaning of Name: Supta means reclined, vira means hero[3]

Category: Restorative Asana
Difficulty Level: Intermediate

Description:
Supta Virasana is presented in Light on Yoga as a reclined variation of Virasana with emphasis on opening the front body. The pose combines hip flexor stretching with supported backbending. The asana requires adequate quadriceps and ankle flexibility.[3][2][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Begin in Virasana, kneeling with the hips between the heels. Support the back with the hands and slowly lower the torso toward the floor. Rest on the elbows initially, then lower completely if comfortable. Arms can rest alongside the body or extend overhead. Hold for 1 to 5 minutes with natural breathing, then carefully rise using the hands for support.[2][3][1]

Benefits:
Supta Virasana stretches the quadriceps, hip flexors, ankles, and abdomen. The pose may reduce digestive discomfort according to traditional understanding. Research on specific benefits is limited. The supported position can promote relaxation when practiced with props.[10][2][1]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary lengthening muscles include the quadriceps, hip flexors, tibialis anterior, and abdominal muscles. The pose involves passive stretching when well-supported. Traditional teachings suggest digestive system influence.[2][1]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with knee injuries should avoid this pose or use extensive support. Those with ankle problems should place padding under the ankles or avoid the pose. Individuals with lower back issues should use props to reduce the backbend.[7]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include attempting the full expression without adequate knee and ankle flexibility. Practitioners often arch the lower back excessively. Forcing the position can cause serious knee injury.[7][1][2]

Variations and Modifications:
Beginners must use a bolster under the entire back for support. Additional blankets can elevate the upper body. Many practitioners should remain on the elbows rather than lowering fully.[1]

Sources:

- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[3][2]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- NCCIH Yoga Guidelines[7]

VIPARITA KARANI (RESTORATIVE VARIATION)

Sanskrit Name: Viparita Karani
English Name: Legs-Up-the-Wall Pose with Bolster
Meaning of Name: Viparita means inverted, karani means action[6][4]

Category: Restorative Asana, Inversion
Difficulty Level: Beginner

Description:
This restorative variation of Viparita Karani uses elevation under the hips for enhanced relaxation. The supported version is commonly taught in restorative yoga classes. The pose combines gentle inversion with passive hip opening.[2][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Place a bolster parallel to a wall approximately 6 inches away. Sit sideways on the bolster and swing the legs up the wall. Lower the shoulders and head to the floor while the hips and sacrum rest on the bolster. Arms rest alongside the body with palms facing up. Allow complete relaxation and hold for 5 to 20 minutes.[2][1]

Benefits:
This variation enhances venous return from the legs. The supported position promotes deep relaxation. Research suggests restorative poses may reduce stress and improve sleep. The gentle opening of the hips adds to the relaxation effect.[7][1]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
All muscles are passively relaxed. The parasympathetic nervous system is activated. The gentle inversion and hip position influence circulation.[7][1]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with glaucoma should avoid even gentle inversions. Pregnant women after the first trimester should elevate the upper body more or avoid the pose. Those with hiatal hernia should avoid the elevated hip position.[9][7]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include using a bolster that is too high or too firm. Practitioners often place the hips too far from the wall. Inadequate duration reduces the restorative benefit.[1][2]

Variations and Modifications:
Blankets can be substituted if a bolster is unavailable. The height can be adjusted for comfort. An eye pillow enhances relaxation.[1]

Sources:

- Hatha Yoga Pradipika[6]

- Gheranda Samhita[4]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[2]
- NCCIH Yoga Benefits[7]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[9]

SUPPORTED MATSYASANA

Sanskrit Name: Matsyasana (Supported)
English Name: Supported Fish Pose
Meaning of Name: Matsya means fish[5][4]

Category: Restorative Asana, Backbend
Difficulty Level: Beginner

Description:
Supported Matsyasana is taught in restorative yoga as a gentle chest and throat opener. The use of props allows passive stretching without muscular effort. The pose provides the benefits of chest opening with minimal risk.[2][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Place a bolster lengthwise on the mat. Sit in front of the bolster and lie back so it supports the spine. Allow the head to rest on the bolster or on a folded blanket for neck support. Legs can extend forward or be in Baddha Konasana. Arms rest alongside the body with palms up or extend to the sides. Hold for 5 to 15 minutes with natural breathing.[2][1]

Benefits:
Supported Matsyasana gently opens the chest and shoulders. The pose promotes relaxation and may reduce stress. Traditional understanding suggests respiratory benefits. The supported position is safe for most practitioners.[5][4][7][1]

Muscles and Systems Involved:
Primary lengthening muscles include the pectoralis major, anterior deltoids, and hip flexors. Passive stretching occurs without active muscular engagement. The open chest position may influence breathing patterns.[1]

Contraindications and Precautions:
Individuals with neck injuries should ensure adequate support under the head and neck. Those with lower back discomfort may need additional support. Pregnant women should use significant elevation under the upper body.[9][7]

Common Mistakes:
Common errors include using inadequate or excessive support. Practitioners often tense the shoulders rather than relaxing. Insufficient time reduces the restorative benefit.[2][1]

Variations and Modifications:
The height and firmness of support can be adjusted with blankets. Leg position can vary for comfort. Additional support under the knees can be added.[1]

Sources:

- Gheranda Samhita[4][5]
- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[2]
- NCCIH Yoga Benefits[7]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[9]

SUPPORTED BALASANA

Sanskrit Name: Balasana (Supported)
English Name: Supported Child's Pose
Meaning of Name: Bala means child[1]

Category: Restorative Asana, Forward Bend
Difficulty Level: Beginner

Description:
Supported Balasana is widely taught in restorative yoga for deep relaxation. The addition of props allows complete release of muscular effort. The pose provides gentle spinal release with maximum comfort.[2][1]

Step-by-Step Practice:
Place a bolster lengthwise between the knees. Kneel with knees wide apart and sit back toward the heels.

Fold forward and rest the torso completely on the bolster. Turn the head to one side. Arms can rest alongside the bolster or extend forward. Hold for 5 to 20 minutes, periodically changing head position.[2][1]

Benefits:

Supported Balasana promotes profound relaxation and stress reduction. The forward fold has calming effects on the nervous system. Research suggests restorative poses may improve sleep quality. The supported position allows extended holds without discomfort.[7][1]

Muscles and Systems Involved:

All muscles are passively relaxed. The parasympathetic nervous system is strongly activated. The gentle compression of the abdomen may influence digestive function.[7][1]

Contraindications and Precautions:

Pregnant women should use a wide knee position and ensure the bolster accommodates the abdomen. Individuals with knee injuries should use padding or modify the position. Those with hip injuries should adjust the position as needed.[9][7]

Common Mistakes:

Common errors include using insufficient support, requiring muscular holding. Practitioners often fail to allow complete release. Inadequate time reduces the restorative effect.[1][2]

Variations and Modifications:

Multiple blankets can be stacked if a bolster is unavailable. The knees can be closer together or wider apart. Additional support under the hips can be added.[1]

Sources:

- Yoga Anatomy, Kaminoff & Matthews[1]
- Light on Yoga, B.K.S. Iyengar[2]
- NCCIH Yoga Benefits[7]
- ACOG Exercise Guidelines[9]